HEX

A cave-diving roguelite of unstable power, every weapon is on a burning fuse.

Game Link: https://krishnarishik.github.io/Hex/
GitHub Link: https://github.com/KrishnaRishik/Hex

1 The pitch: what it is, who it's for, why play

A real-time, gravity-driven cave platformer about **unstable power**. You drop through procedurally generated caves grabbing cursed weapon cores, each on a fuse that counts down with every shot. You hold one and queue up to three more, as fuses burn out, your queue feeds you the next curse. Between depths you spend gold at a black market. The hook isn't collecting a build; it's managing a stream of weapons you can't keep.

Who it's for: players who love the lethal, readable chaos of *Nuclear Throne* and the "one-more-run" pull of *Noita*, but are tired of builds that snowball into autopilot. Short sessions (2–6 min), high readability, keyboard + mouse, instant in any browser.

Why play: the core decision is novel and constant, keep firing this weapon toward detonation, or hold it and let the fuse hand off cleanly to what you've queued. Every fuse hitting zero is a tiny risk/reward beat, and the run never lets you coast.

2 Core loop & first session

The loop (~15s): move and jump through the cave, read your fuse, fire toward it, decide *keep* firing or let it run out into your queu*e,* pick up new curses to stock the queue, clear the floor, (at set depths) shop, then descend.

First 3 minutes: you start with one weapon and a 3-slot queue, and a fuse meter that's the most prominent thing on screen. You shoot, the fuse flashes red and physically shakes, and at zero your next queued curse takes over or, if you're empty, it backfires for a chunk of health and conjures a fresh weapon. That single moment teaches the whole game with no tutorial: power here is temporary; keep a buffer or pay for it. By minute three you've cycled through several weapons, learned to grab curses to keep the queue stocked, and cleared your first floor.

3 Progression, the day-1 hook, and the long game

The day-1 hook (built and persistent):

- **The Ledger:** an unlock ladder of run-modifiers at depth milestones (1, 3, 5, 8, 12). The first unlock fires on a brand-new player's **very first run**, so progression is felt immediately.
- **The black market + a gold wallet that persists between runs:** You earn gold from kills, it banks across runs, and you spend it in a shop, both from the menu (your starting loadout) and at checkpoints after depths 3, 5, 10, then every two floors. Earning toward a curse you want is a concrete reason to start tomorrow's run.
- **Daily Curse:** a date-seeded run with a fixed start and a local best. "New seed at midnight" is the literal return driver.

Why this hook fits this game: the fantasy is volatility, so the metagame doesn't hand out permanent power that contradicts it.

Months-long: an ever-widening weapon space (the conjure-on-empty system means the pool literally keeps growing), depth bosses, a deeper shop economy, weekly seeded leaderboards on the daily, and a "curses seen" collection log. The daily seed is the social/competitive spine.

4 Monetization

The full run is **free and complete,** no energy timers, no paywalled floors, and crucially **gold is earned**
in-game, never sold, so the shop can't become pay-to-win. Monetization sits on top of a game that's already fun for free:

- **Cosmetic** curse-skins, weapon palettes, death-cry flavors. Zero power.
- **One-time "Collector's Pass"** (a single purchase, not a battle-pass treadmill): cosmetic tracks + daily leaderboard history. Bought once, owned forever.
- **Opt-in rewarded "second chance":** offered only on death, never interrupts a run, never required to progress.

The line I won't cross: nothing that sells power or gameplay gold, gates content, or makes the free game deliberately worse. A roguelite lives on trust in its RNG and its economy.

5 AI: how I used it to build, and where it lives in the game

How AI built it. The whole prototype, cave generation, the fuse and queue systems, the platformer physics, enemy AI, the shop economy, and the UI, was built with an AI coding assistant (Claude) from a design brief, iterated in a tight loop, and hardened with **automated tests** (collision simulated across 200+ caves, reachability verified across 400+ seeds; the damage/death and fuse rules unit-checked). No art, shapes and colors do the work.

Where AI is in the game. Found and shop weapons come from a curated, learnable pool. But when your queue runs dry and the fuse backfires, the curse **conjures a fresh weapon,** its name, stats, projectile behaviors, and flavors line generated into a constrained schema and validated before it reaches your hands. The game stands on the fuse loop with or without it. It's engineered to be robust.

6 Shipping

Test first (in order):

- Is the core loop fun for 5 minutes with zero metagame? If the fuse decision isn't compelling on its own, nothing else matters. Pure playtest.
- Does the fuse read instantly, and does the queue hand-off feel good rather than abrupt?
- Is the explode-vs-clean-handoff and the shop economy fair? Tune from real data.

What kills it or pivots it:

- If players read the fuse as a **frustrating interruption** rather than an interesting gamble, the central mechanic is wrong and the game doesn't exist. That's the kill signal.
- If sessions are fun but no one returns, the loop works but the meta doesn't.

7 Reference games, borrowed & diverged

- **Downwell**: borrowed: vertical descent, “keep going down,” shooting-down-to-control-your-fall.
- **Noita**: borrowed: organic PCG caves weapon changing systems.

The thing none of them do, that this is built around: weapons that are temporary by mechanic, a fuse and a queue. So power is a stream you manage, not abuse.